

portion for typing your search query—for example, 'Linux'. The top empty portion tells you to "Type a Word or Phrase". Easy, right?

This display is an 8.9-cm (3.5 inch) reflective monochrome LCD with a resolution of 240x208 pixels. And yes, it's a capacitive touchscreen; so you press the on-screen keypad with your bare fingers to enter the word/phrase you want to look for. Well this is where I came across my first obstacle. Either my fingers are too fat, or the screen space is too inadequate—I found myself often pressing the wrong characters. Also, you need to press a little bit harder to strike a note here. Makes me wonder, wouldn't a resistive screen have made better sense—I could have used a stylus.

Moving on, as you start entering the characters for your query, the top part of the screen shows you possible entries you might be looking for—it only shows five options, and there's no way you can scroll down to see if there are more matches. Could have been quite a handy option, don't you think? Upon entering Linux, it displays the following five options: 'LINUX', 'LinuX', 'Linux', 'Linux (disambiguation)' and 'Linux (GNU/Linux)'. All of them will take you to the Wikipedia entry on Linux, except for 'Linux (disambiguation)', of course.

So, I started to read the article on Linux, and I stumbled upon something weird right on the second word. It read: 'Linux (commonly...) is a generic term referring to Unix-like computer operating systems based on the Linux kernel...' You'd wonder what's missing after the word 'commonly'. Well, it seems they have removed the phonetics. Or possibly they haven't, and something is wrong with the rendering that's stopping the characters from showing up. Since I can't really understand phonetics, it doesn't matter to me much. But still, it's something for the manufacturer to check on when a new update to the Wiki database is released.

The manufacturer also needs to come up with a way to represent tables, somehow. In its current form, articles like [http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Comparison\\_of\\_relational\\_database\\_management\\_systems](http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Comparison_of_relational_database_management_systems) only display the subheads, while the tables that are the actual content under the subheads are missing. It's understandable that inserting a table into this sort device with a smaller screen size is troublesome, and I've heard that Om is already working on a way to take care of this issue. So, a future update could solve this problem too.

Why updating all this is possible is because the whole content is stored in a microSD card. You can easily take it out by removing the batteries. So when the manufacturer releases an update to the database, you can download it onto your PC and copy it over to this microSD card. You also have an option to order updated cards by snail mail—they ship you a new microSD card for a fee. More details are here: <http://thewikireader.com/update.html>.

Anyway, going again back to that Linux article, you might have noticed that I've left some words underlined



▲ What's inside the box

while quoting the opening sentence. These are basically the same Wikipedia hyperlinks that take you to the Wiki article on the hyperlinked word/phrase. It works as expected on this device too.

One thing I would like to point out is, when you click on one of these links, there's no back button to come back to the previous article you were reading. So, the only way is to press the 'History' button, which keeps a tab on all the articles you've previously accessed.

Talking about reading articles, the display resolution can hold a maximum of 13 lines of text with approximately 38 characters per line. The font size is adequate, making reading entries quite comfortable. What could be discomforting is the absence of any backlighting. So, you can only use this device at a comparatively brightly-lit place. Also, since the screen doesn't support colours, it obviously doesn't display any pictures.

This pretty much sums up my brief report on the WikiReader. Did I miss something? Oh yes, it runs on battery power. Not some hard-to-find-in-a-general-store Li-Ion battery, but two AAA batteries that are quite easy to find. Om claims the battery life is approximately 90 hours, which I'd say is quite decent. Besides, they have designed the Reader such that if it's inactive for a while, it automatically shuts off—a good power-saving technique. You might think restarting the device again is a headache. But considering it only takes a second to boot up, and a few more seconds to press 'history' and retrieve the article you were reading, it isn't much of a pain.

My verdict? Go for it! It's a handy present for your child or even for yourself, if you're a Wiki addict. Well, you have the 'random' button to take you to places—most of which, I'm sure, you wouldn't have visited because you never knew they existed. **END** 

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